



Inflation monitor: PPI overshoots as history repeats itself

China's April PPI inflation significantly exceeded expectations, surging to 2.8% YoY, indicating a broadening trend of price hikes. The rise in energy and industrial product prices also propelled a CPI rebound, counteracting falling food prices. Although PPI's jump was a surprise, it is consistent with historical patterns that point to further increases. Consequently, we revise up 2026 inflation forecasts to 3.2% for PPI and 1.6% for CPI.

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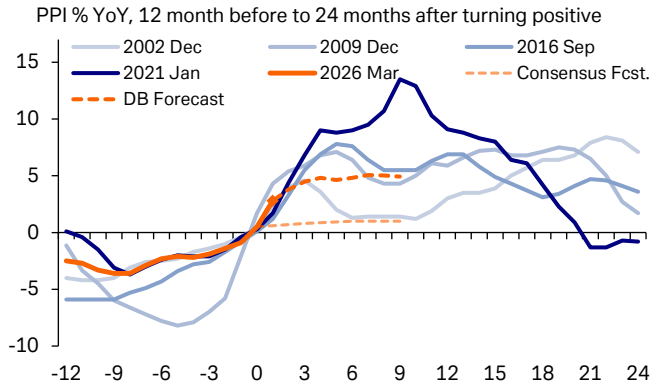
China's PPI inflation rose much faster than expected in April. Headline PPI jumped to 2.8% YoY from 0.5% in March. Prices rose 1.7% MoM sequentially, almost doubling the 0.9% MoM increase in March. Price increases were led by petroleum, with its extraction and processing showing higher MoM growth. Notably, this price increase has transmitted to the chemical industry, as evidenced by higher growth in prices for chemical materials, rubber, and plastics compared to March. The increase of prices in other upstream and midstream products, such as coal, metals, fibres and textile, points to a potential broadening of PPI inflation and increased pass-through of prices.

Energy and industrial product prices drove a rebound in CPI, offsetting the impact of falling food prices. Food inflation remained below seasonality and turned negative to -0.8% YoY, dragged down by pork prices (-15% YoY) and broad price cut in vegetable and fruits. However, CPI further rose to 1.2% YoY from 1.0%, supported by rising energy prices and core inflation. Fuel prices surged to 17.4% YoY, contributing 0.45ppt to overall CPI inflation (0.15ppt in March). Core CPI outperformed seasonality and recorded 1.2% YoY growth (+0.1ppt). Transmission from rising PPI to CPI is beginning to happen, with industrial consumer goods prices rising by 3.5% YoY, driven by prices of products such as gasoline, automobiles, and mobile phones. Meanwhile, service inflation strengthened to 0.9% YoY, higher than the 0.83% in Q1 and 0.7% in Q4 2025. As demonstrated in the [Labor Day holiday note](#), services consumption has been a highlight and will likely support CPI inflation.

We revise up our inflation forecast. Although PPI's jump in April was a surprise, it is consistent with historical patterns (see our note [A Short Guide to RMB Assets in a PPI Reflation](#)). We revise up 2026 PPI annual forecast to 3.2% (+1.4 ppt), expecting it to reach 5% in the second half. CPI forecast is also lifted to 1.6% (+0.1 ppt), likely reaching 2.0% by year end. The improved inflation outlook would further benefit [recovering industrial profits](#).

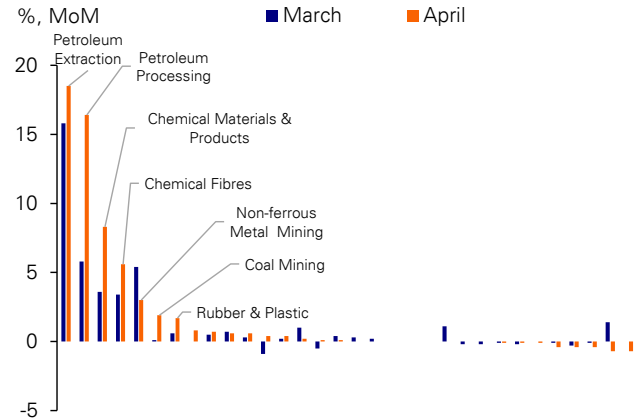


Figure 1: PPI rose rapidly in April after turning positive in March; this is consistent with historical patterns



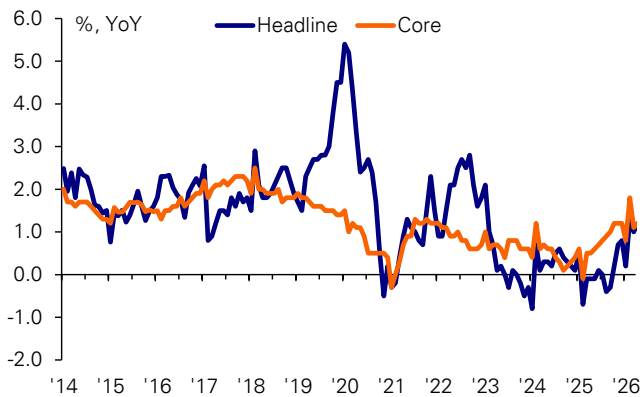
Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

Figure 2: PPI improvement was transmitting to midstream industries



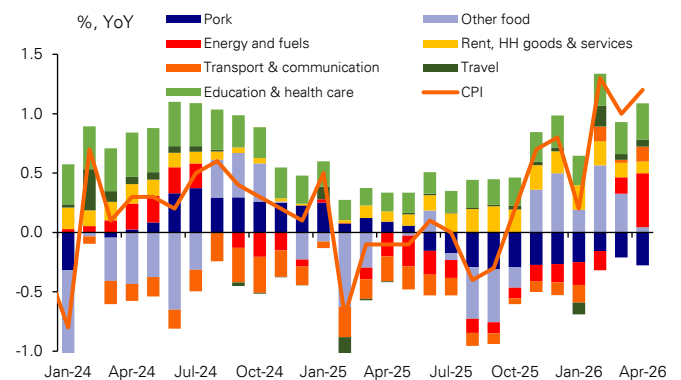
Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

Figure 3: Headline CPI and core CPI inflation were stronger



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

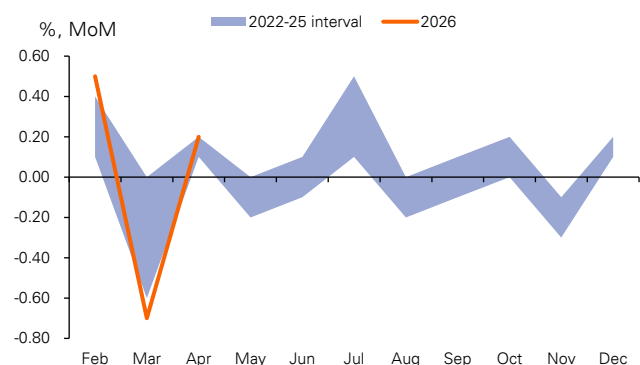
Figure 4: Energy was the largest contributor in April



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

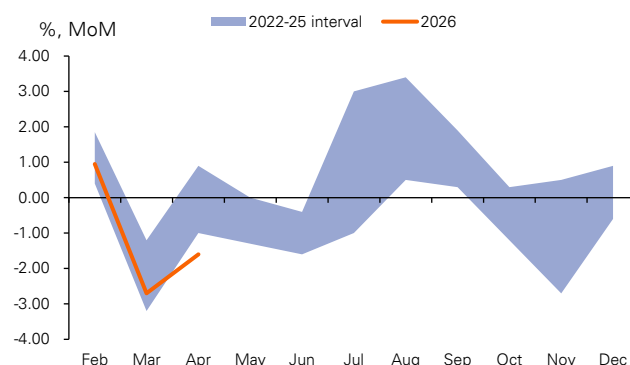


Figure 5: Core inflation outperformed seasonality



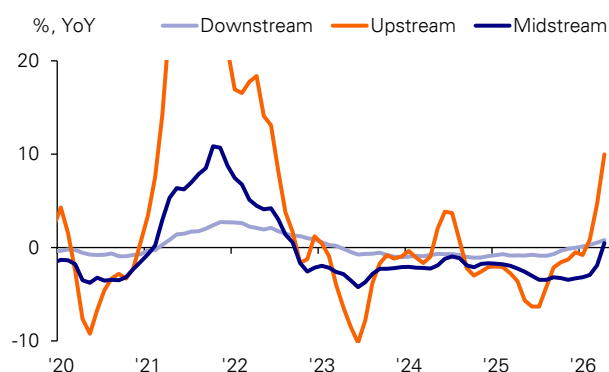
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Figure 6: Food inflation was weaker than seasonality



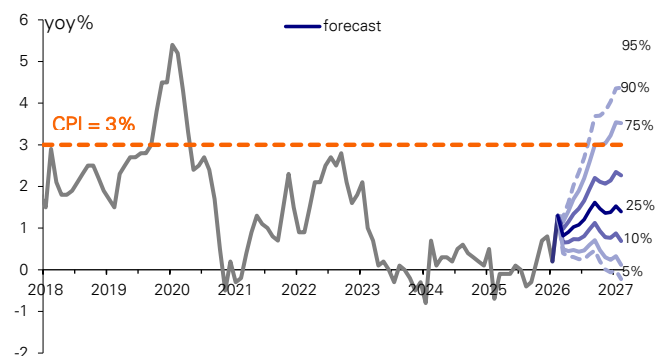
Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

Figure 7: Upstream led the PPI improvement, followed by midstream



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS, Wind

Figure 8: Annual CPI forecast is revised to 1.6%



Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

Figure 9: April inflation momentum

% YoY	21avg	22avg	23avg	24avg	Oct-25	Nov-25	Dec-25	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26
Headline CPI	0.9	2.0	0.2	0.2	0.2	0.7	0.8	0.2	1.3	1.0	1.2
Core CPI	0.8	0.9	0.7	0.5	1.2	1.2	1.2	0.8	1.8	1.1	1.2
Food, Tobacco and Liquor	-0.3	2.5	0.3	-0.1	-1.6	0.3	0.8	-0.2	1.4	0.4	-1.6
Clothing	0.3	0.5	1.0	1.4	1.7	1.9	1.7	1.9	1.9	1.6	1.5
Housing	0.8	0.7	0.0	0.1	0.1	0.0	-0.2	-0.1	-0.2	-0.2	-0.2
Household Articles & Services	0.4	1.2	0.1	0.5	1.9	2.1	2.2	2.6	2.8	1.5	1.4
Transportation and Communication	4.2	5.2	-2.3	-1.9	-1.5	-2.3	-2.6	-3.4	-0.7	0.9	4.6
Recreation, Education and Cultural Svcs	1.9	1.8	2.0	1.5	0.9	0.8	0.9	0.0	2.0	1.1	1.3
Medicine, Medical Care, Personal Articles	0.4	0.6	1.1	1.3	1.4	1.6	1.8	1.7	1.9	1.9	2.2
PPI	8.1	4.2	-3.0	-2.2	-2.1	-2.2	-1.9	-1.4	-0.9	0.5	2.80
Mining & Quarrying	34.8	18.7	-7.6	-2.8	-7.8	-6.1	-4.7	-8.1	-5.3	2.0	10.60
Raw Materials	15.9	10.7	-4.3	-1.6	-2.5	-2.9	-2.6	-2.0	-1.9	1.1	7.10
Manufacturing	6.7	1.6	-3.3	-2.9	-1.9	-1.9	-1.6	-0.4	0.3	0.9	1.50

Source : Deutsche Bank Research, NBS

Note: The number in each cell represents the yoy change of each item. The cell color represents the z-score of CPI inflationary momentum. The further below the 5-yr average, the greener the color gets, while red reflects inflationary pressure well above the historical average.



Appendix 1

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